35

Léa

They drove for an hour on roads teeming with people. Small groups of men and women dressed in rags or shabby uniforms, pulled carts with all their possessions. They looked like vagabonds, aimless, wandering, stopping to rest on the side of the road. The driver swore at them, shouting that they should get off the road. Outside of Dohma, a line of cars stood at a roadblock. Men in plainclothes pointed rifles, asking questions. The driver clicked his tongue, tapping his fingers on the gear shift.

André opened the note and read it, then folded it and held it to his heart. He glanced at Léa, his eyes burning with tears.

She wanted to ask what the note said, but the driver, grinding the gear into reverse, suddenly backed up, nearly smashing the car behind, then turned and sped off. Gunshots hit the metal trunk. André pulled Léa down, bending over her and Katya.

"Are you all right?" Josef asked, turning to the back seat.

André sat up and checked Léa and Katya. "We're all fine."

"Where are we going now?" Josef said.

"Valley roads." The driver crunched the gears. "Main roads too dangerous."

"Let's return to Glashütte," Léa said, reaching for Josef's hand.

"No. You go to the other side of the Elbe," the driver said.

Josef held her hand. "One of us will go back with him and find her."

For a moment, Léa believed him. She wanted to believe that Rose had made a simple mistake that anyone could have made, like getting off at the wrong tram stop.

They veered off the main road, skidding on the asphalt as the car turned